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To diff directory trees on macOS, use the native **Terminal** `diff` command for a fast, built-in solution, or **FileMerge** if you prefer a graphical user interface. [Stack Exchange](#) +1

Command Line (Terminal)

The standard Unix `diff` utility is built directly into the macOS operating system. Open your Terminal app (`/Applications/Utilities/Terminal`) and use one of the following variations depending on your needs. [Macworld](#) +2

1. Brief Summary (Recommended)

To see only a list of which files differ or exist exclusively in one folder without printing line-by-line file content changes, run: [Stack Exchange](#) +2

bash

```
diff -rq /path/to/folder1 /path/to/folder2
```

Use code with caution.



- `-r` : Recursively searches through all subdirectories.
- `-q` : Brief mode; outputs only the names of files that differ. [Stack Exchange](#) +1

2. Hide `.DS_Store` Noise

macOS automatically generates hidden `.DS_Store` metadata files which can clutter your results. To filter them out and save the output into a text file, run: [Stack Exchange](#) +2

bash

```
diff -rq /path/to/folder1 /path/to/folder2 | grep -v '.DS_Store' > diff_re
```

Use code with caution.

